

UNITED NATIONS



NATIONS UNIES

DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL AFFAIRS

**ITALIAN FELLOWSHIPS PROGRAMME
FOR TECHNICAL COOPERATION
CAPACITY BUILDING AND HUMAN RESOURCES DEVELOPMENT
2025-2026**

Fellowship Award Specification

**United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF)
Georgia Country Office**

1. General Information

<u>Title:</u>	UN Fellow
<u>Orientation Workshop dates:</u>	May 2026 (tbc)
<u>Assignment in the field dates:</u>	May 2026 – May 2027 (tbc)
<u>Duty Station:</u>	Tbilisi, Georgia
<u>Sector of assignment:</u>	Social Policy, Public finance for children

2. Supervision

<u>Name of the Supervisor:</u>	Ms. Ketevan Melikadze
<u>Title of the Supervisor:</u>	Social Policy and Economic Specialist
<u>Name of the Direct Supervisor</u>	Ms. Nino Davitashvili
<u>Title of the Direct Supervisor:</u>	Social Policy Officer

3. Background information

The fundamental mission of UNICEF is to promote the rights of every child, everywhere, in all aspects of its work—programs, advocacy, and operations. The equity strategy focuses on the most disadvantaged and excluded children and families, translating this commitment to children's rights into action. For UNICEF, equity means that all children have the opportunity to survive, develop, and reach their full potential without discrimination, bias, or favoritism.

When any child faces unequal opportunities in social, political, economic, civic, or cultural dimensions, their rights are violated. There is increasing evidence that investing in the health, education, and protection of a society's most disadvantaged citizens—addressing inequity—not only enables all children to fulfill their potential but also fosters sustained growth and stability within countries. This focus on equity is crucial; it accelerates progress toward realizing the human rights of all children, as mandated by the Convention on the Rights of the Child, while also promoting the equitable development of nations.

Job organizational context:

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child mandates that governments allocate resources to ensure every child's survival, development, and protection. In alignment with this, the EU-Georgia Association Agreement upholds children's rights, focusing on their protection, education, and healthcare. To meet international obligations and invest in its future, Georgia must enhance social protection, expand services, and prioritize children's well-being, addressing gaps in their access to resources.

Recent global estimates from the World Bank and UNICEF reveal that twice as many children live in extreme poverty compared to adults. In 2022, the National Statistics Office of Georgia

(Geostat) reported that the multidimensional child poverty rate, measured through the child social and material deprivation index, stands at 37.8%. This measurement was conducted as part of the Child Welfare Survey, supported by UNICEF. In Georgia, 16.0% of children live in absolute poverty, compared to 11.8% of adults. (Geostat, 2024)

Currently, Georgia spends less than the global average on social protection. In 2023, the Georgian government allocated 7.3% of GDP to social protection, significantly lower than the OECD average of 14.6%, where member countries benefit from stronger and more comprehensive social protection systems.

Recent studies in Georgia (Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey, 2018; Child Welfare Survey, 2022 etc.) show that absolute poverty among children aged 0 to 15 years is significantly higher than any other age group, affecting 20.4 percent of children in the country. Poverty, material deprivation and social exclusion are more pronounced in rural areas, where some groups face a higher risk of poverty, especially families with children.

In 2015, the government introduced the Child Benefit (CB) program, initially set at 10 GEL (approximately \$4 in 2015) and increasing to 200 GEL (around \$75 in 2023). CB is part of the Targeted Social Assistance (TSA) program, benefiting approximately 26% of children under 16 in households with a socioeconomic score of less than 120,001 (about 232,000 children in 2023). However, access to this aid is linked to poverty and does not cover all children.

In 2019, Georgia adopted the Child Rights Code, which establishes legal grounds, safeguards, and guarantees for the realization of all children's rights and freedoms, focusing on ensuring the best interests of the child in decision-making at all levels. Despite this progress, the country still lacks specific legal or political commitments to guarantee a universal basic income for children. The Code emphasizes the need to safeguard children's rights across all levels of government, necessitating adequate funding for various programs.

Children are particularly vulnerable to poverty and experience long-term consequences from deprivation, which can hinder their cognitive and physiological development. A crucial social policy tool aimed at eradicating child poverty and improving well-being is the Universal Child Benefit (UCB). Implementing such a program requires significant government commitment and sufficient fiscal capacity.

According to Georgia's development strategy, Vision 2030, the government has prioritized establishing a sustainable, fair, and effective social protection system. It is committed to expanding, improving, and increasing state spending on social assistance for the most vulnerable families, especially those with children.

In recent years, Public Financial Management (PFM) in Georgia has undergone significant reforms to enhance transparency, efficiency, and accountability within the fiscal framework. The country has actively pursued reforms aligned with international best practices, focusing on modernizing budgetary

processes, strengthening financial oversight, and improving expenditure management. Key initiatives include the introduction of program-based budgeting, enhancing the Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF), and implementing electronic procurement systems to improve transparency. Additionally, Georgia has emphasized fiscal transparency through enhanced reporting mechanisms and has engaged in capacity-building efforts to strengthen the skills within its financial institutions.

In this context, strengthening UNICEF's Public Finance Work for Children (PF4C) is of utmost importance. An effectively implemented PFM framework ensures transparent budget allocations and efficient resource utilization, enabling targeted PF4C initiatives that prioritize essential services for children. UNICEF Georgia has developed a multi-year PF4C Action Plan that aligns with UNICEF's global framework on public finance for children. As part of this plan, UNICEF is engaged in developing a specialized methodology to conduct comprehensive municipal budget reviews and formulate child rights-focused budget briefs. The goal is to methodically examine municipal budgets through the lens of child rights, addressing the allocation and utilization of funds to ensure the effective fulfillment of children's rights at the local governance level. This groundwork lays the foundation for future scrutiny of the central budget from a child rights perspective, facilitating a holistic approach to safeguarding and promoting children's welfare across the nation.

The objective of the Social Policy Section's work in the area of PF4C is to generate evidence regarding public allocations and investments for children, while advocating and actively engaging with national and local authorities (and their partners) to contribute to the development of child-focused socio-economic and PFM reforms.

4. Duties, responsibilities and output expectations:

This role will provide critical assistance in strengthening country-level work in public finance for children (PF4C). Specifically, the incumbent will focus on enhancing UNICEF's engagement in public financial management (PFM) at both the local and national levels. UNICEF has extensive experience in this area, with a wide array of methodologies, guidelines, and best practices available.

Initially, the section will provide comprehensive support to the incumbent, gradually shifting responsibilities while maintaining oversight of their work.

The incumbent will contribute through various actions, including but not limited to: conducting analyses and research, writing briefs and reports, developing advocacy messages, applying PF4C tools, contributing to guidelines, improving national knowledge management platforms, and creating communication products.

The incumbent will work closely with UNICEF Georgia's social policy team. Occasionally, they may be asked to explore emerging issues, particularly in the area of public finance. The incumbent may also collaborate with external partners, including the World Bank, IMF, UNDP, UNFPA, line ministries, the Ministry of Finance, municipalities, and academia on joint initiatives.

Summary of key functions/accountabilities:

1. Support the Social Policy team in technical engagement in sectoral public financial management (PFM) by developing and strengthening methodologies for assessing national and local budgets through a child rights lens, sharing best practices, and providing quality assurance.
 - Contribute to refining the methodology for local government budget assessments with a child rights perspective.
 - Contribute to the development of a methodology for central budget assessments with a child rights lens.
 - Assist in Advocating for investing in children through:

- Evidence generation and advocacy
- Engagement with public authorities in planning and budgeting for child-specific programs
- Participatory planning and budgeting
- Financing strategies and resource mobilization

Throughout this process, the incumbent will build strong relationships in the field and deepen their understanding of UNICEF's work in Georgia, particularly by supporting technical engagement in strengthening sectoral public financial management (PFM).

Output (Achievement) Expected

- Collect, verify, organize data on social spending from the selected municipal or central budgets
 - Develop a compendium of good cases, including working documents, from selected municipalities
 - Using various UNICEF's public financial analysis tools to create analytical notes as requested by different sectors of the UNICEF Georgia office.
 - Contribute to the development of the PF4C Observatory concept and support its implementation.
2. Contribute to strengthening UNICEF's public financial management at national and subnational levels
- Contribute to assessing country's governance context especially public finance management
 - Contribute to assessing country's local governance specifically, and the pace of decentralization reforms
 - Contribute to the development of the municipal child-oriented budgeting index.

Output (Achievement) Expected

- Design a framework for assessing entry points for local governments in Georgia.
 - Initiate the development of partnerships with external stakeholders.
3. Contribute to the implementation of CO PF4C action plan

Output (Achievement) Expected

- Design the monitoring and evaluation framework for Country office Public Finance for Children Action Plan
 - Track the implementation of its activity.
 - Update the action plan annually or bi-annually as required
4. Contribute to critical thinking with attention to how to integrate to the core of UNICEF PF4C

5. Qualifications and Experience

Education

An advanced university degree in one of the following fields is required in: Development Economics, Public Finance, International Finance, Economics and Statistics.

Work experience

One year of relevant, proven professional work experience in economy, public finance, PFM reforms of developing countries or field work experience. Relevant experience in a UN system agency or organization is considered as an asset.

Languages

Fluency in English is required.

Competencies

Core Values

- Care
- Respect
- Integrity
- Trust
- Accountability
- Sustainability

6. Learning Elements

At the end of the assignment the Fellow will gain a strong understanding of UNICEF's social policy and Public Finance for Children (PF4C) approach, including:

- Applying PF4C tools to assess national and municipal budgets through a child rights lens.
- Conducting evidence-based analyses and contributing to budget briefs, reports, and advocacy products.
- Supporting program design, monitoring, and evaluation aligned with UNICEF's results-based management principles.
- Engaging with government counterparts, municipalities, and development partners to promote equitable investment in children.
- Strengthening analytical, technical writing, and communication skills while contributing to UNICEF's PF4C knowledge base.

7. Content and methodology of the supervision

The Fellow will work under the supervision of the **Social Policy Specialist** and closely with the Social Policy team.

- **Orientation:** An initial briefing will introduce UNICEF's mandate, office structure, and ongoing PF4C initiatives, followed by a joint work plan.
- **Regular guidance:** Weekly or bi-weekly meetings will review progress and provide technical mentoring.
- **Team engagement:** The fellow will participate in section meetings, knowledge-sharing sessions, and, where relevant, field activities.
- **Reporting:** Short progress updates and a final report will be submitted, with feedback provided by the supervisor.

8. Living conditions in the country

Georgia offers a safe and welcoming environment, with Tbilisi serving as the main duty station. The city provides comfortable housing, reliable public transport, and good access to healthcare and other essential services. The cost of living is moderate compared to Western Europe, though prices are higher in Tbilisi than in smaller towns.

Internet connectivity is fast and stable, and most amenities—cafés, supermarkets, and fitness centers—are easily accessible. English is increasingly spoken among younger people and professionals. The climate is mild, with hot summers and cool winters.

While overall living standards continue to improve, conditions and services can vary between urban and rural areas. Fellows are advised to have health insurance and follow standard precautions regarding food and water safety when traveling outside major cities. Georgia provides a comfortable and culturally rich setting for work and daily life. The Security Level in Georgia is classified as Moderate

(Level 3) as per the UN security management system in Georgia, in all of Georgia. Overall situation in Georgia is calm and presents a low-risk environment for UN.

The housing market in Tbilisi offers diverse options for accommodation. With a good network of public transportation, staff can explore housing opportunities in various areas, including both sides of the city.

Work opportunities for spouses/partners are available in the private sector as Tbilisi, the capital of Georgia, has experienced growth in its private sector, which has contributed to increased work opportunities. However, if hired by any organization a work permit must be applied for through the same hiring organization.